



The Other Half of the Song

Teacher copy (everything in the student copy, plus answers and teaching notes)

The article, marked for rhetorical devices (one color throughout):

1 Peabo Bryson, who died this week at seventy-five, had one of the great voices of his time, and he spent it, more often than not, making room for another. He was a soloist by gift and a partner by instinct.

[Antithesis] The songs the world kept were the ones he sang with someone beside him.

2 You know the songs even if you have let the name slip. The ballroom melody from 'Beauty and the Beast', the one he sang with Celine Dion. The carpet ride from Aladdin, 'A Whole New World', the one he sang with Regina Belle, which climbed to the top of the pop chart, the first song from an animated film ever to do it. Before those, the slow turn of 'Tonight, I Celebrate My Love', beside Roberta Flack. Three of the songs that made his name were three songs he gave away half of.

3 This is not to slight the solo work. There was plenty of it, going back to a teenager singing in Greenville and a first hit before he was thirty. His voice alone could fill a room, warm and unhurried and sure of the note before he reached it [Polysyndeton]. But a voice like that can crowd a duet, can win it, can leave the other singer sounding small. His never did. He sang with people, not over them. That is harder than singing alone, and rarer, and he made it sound like the easiest thing in the world.

4 There is a kind of talent that needs to be the only light in the room. His was the other kind. To sing a duet well is to listen as much as to sound, to bend your own gift toward someone else's and let the blend be the point. He did that for the better part of his life, and the proof is in the recordings: two voices, and no seam where they meet [Metaphor].

5 He won two Grammys, both for duets, which feels exactly right. He could have chased the solo spotlight and the bigger name that comes with it. He reached instead for the harmonized line, the shared credit, the song that needed two people to be itself [Asyndeton]. It was the humbler choice and the better one, and it is why the songs have outlived the charts.

6 The voice is on the records now, where it will go on doing the thing it did best, which was to make whoever stood beside him sound like the only other person in the world. A soloist is mourned by his listeners. A duet partner is mourned by the voice that has lost its other half. Peabo Bryson leaves a great many of both. Rest him gently. [Telegraphic sentence]

Devices, and why they are here:

Antithesis (paragraph 1): "He was a soloist by gift and a partner by instinct."

'A soloist by gift and a partner by instinct' sets his natural talent against his natural choice in one balanced line, stating the contrast the whole tribute runs on before a single song is named.

Polysyndeton (paragraph 3): “warm and unhurried and sure of the note before he reached it”

The piled-up 'and's in 'warm and unhurried and sure of the note' slow the line to the unhurried pace of the voice it describes, giving each quality its own beat instead of rushing them into a list.

Metaphor (paragraph 4): “two voices, and no seam where they meet”

'No seam where they meet' borrows the language of sewing to describe two blended voices, turning an abstract praise of harmony into something the ear can picture as a single, jointless cloth.

Asyndeton (paragraph 5): “the harmonized line, the shared credit, the song that needed two people to be itself”

Dropping every conjunction from 'the harmonized line, the shared credit, the song that needed two people' does the opposite of the earlier piled 'and's: the three chosen things rush together in one breath, the unbroken list enacting the gathering it names.

Telegraphic sentence (paragraph 6): “Rest him gently.”

The closing three-word benediction, 'Rest him gently,' lands after the longest sentences in the piece, and its plainness is the restraint the register prizes: grandeur made by stripping away, not by piling on.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. Which of the following best characterizes the central claim the writer makes about Bryson's career?
 - A) that what most deserves honor is his choice to share songs, not the solo talent that would have let him dominate them
 - B) that his solo recordings were the true measure of his gift and the duets a distraction
 - C) that his duets worked only because his partners were more famous than he was
 - D) that he went underrated because he so rarely recorded on his own
2. The writer's attitude toward Bryson across the piece is best described as
 - A) fond but quietly critical of the choices that cost him greater fame
 - B) detached and evenhanded, weighing his strengths against his flaws
 - C) admiring, with the admiration aimed less at his talent than at his restraint
 - D) grieving to the point of treating his death as a national catastrophe

Multiple choice answer key:

1. Answer A. The piece grants his solo gift in full, a voice that could 'fill a room,' then honors the harder choice to sing with people, not over them, and closes on the duet partner's loss. Crediting the partners' greater fame imports a claim the piece never makes and undercuts its praise of his own voice (out-of-passage import). Calling the solo work the true measure inverts the writer's stated emphasis on the shared songs (inverted relationship). Saying he went underrated for rarely recording alone misstates the text, which says there was 'plenty' of solo work (true-sounding but unsupported).

2. Answer C. The praise settles again and again on what he chose to do with his voice, blend it, share it, leave the room warmer, rather than on the voice alone. The 'national catastrophe' option overstates a tone the piece keeps quiet and intimate (over-broad). The 'quietly critical' option misreads the writer, who calls the duet path 'the humbler choice and the better one,' not a loss (inverted relationship). The 'detached and evenhanded' option mistakes the restrained style for neutrality when the piece is plainly reverent (right device, wrong effect).

Discussion questions:

1. The writer claims that singing a good duet 'is harder than singing alone, and rarer.' How convincing is that claim as the piece makes it? What supports it, and what would you want added?
2. The piece dwells on the songs Bryson shared more than on his solo career. What does that choice tell you about what the writer wants the reader to value, and is anything lost by it?

Sample strong discussion responses:

1. A strong answer points to the reasoning that a powerful voice can 'crowd a duet' and 'leave the other singer sounding small,' so blending rather than dominating is a genuine skill, not mere modesty. A student might add that the claim leans more on assertion than evidence, and that one specific moment from a recording would make it land harder.
2. A strong answer recognizes the writer is honoring generosity over showmanship and using the duets to define the man. What is lost is a fuller sense of his solo artistry, which the piece grants exists but sets aside; a reader who wants the whole musician would need more than the tribute's chosen frame.

Writing prompt (in-class or homework, Q2 rhetorical analysis):

Write an essay analyzing the rhetorical choices the writer uses to honor Peabo Bryson. Consider how antithesis (the soloist set against the partner), understatement and restraint, the handling of concrete detail (the named songs and partners), and the closing benediction work together to shape the tribute.

Common misconceptions to watch for:

- Students may take the piece as a straightforward sad obituary. Its argument is more specific: it honors a particular choice, to share the song, and most of its devices serve that claim rather than simple grief.
- The piece uses both asyndeton and polysyndeton, and students mix them up. Count the conjunctions: 'warm and unhurried and sure' repeats 'and' (polysyndeton, which slows the line); 'the harmonized line, the shared credit, the song' drops them (asyndeton, which speeds it). Same list shape, opposite effect.
- Students often label 'He was a soloist by gift and a partner by instinct' parallelism. It is antithesis: two contrasting roles set in balanced form. Reserve 'parallelism' for matched structure without that built-in opposition.

AP exam alignment:

Q2 rhetorical-analysis value: a compact model of the consecratory mode, where grandeur comes from restraint rather than superlatives. Strong for teaching antithesis as a structural engine (soloist against partner), the asyndeton-versus-polysyndeton contrast in two nearby series, and how a writer builds praise through concrete particulars (named songs and partners) and a quiet benediction rather than asserted emotion.